Generative AI Can Harm Teaching

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University of Pennsylvania

INFORMS Annual Meeting 2026

Overview

We randomly assigned teachers to get an AI assistant or teach as usual.
Most adopted it, mostly delegating rather than co-creating.
Their students found class less interesting, enjoyable, and important.
Standardized test scores held on average but fell for students
of weaker teachers. Teachers did not update their views on AI.

Teachers already use generative AI

60%

of U.S. K-12 teachers used an AI tool last school year

Gallup & Walton Family Foundation 2025

1/3

use it every week

Gallup & Walton Family Foundation 2025

No causal evidence on its effects on students.

AI could increase or decrease the quality of teaching

Optimistic

High-quality content.

Time freed for rehearsal, relationships and differentiation.

Oreopoulos et al. 2024

Pessimistic

Teachers offload the pedagogical thinking.

Materials come out polished but generic.

Time saved might not be reinvested.

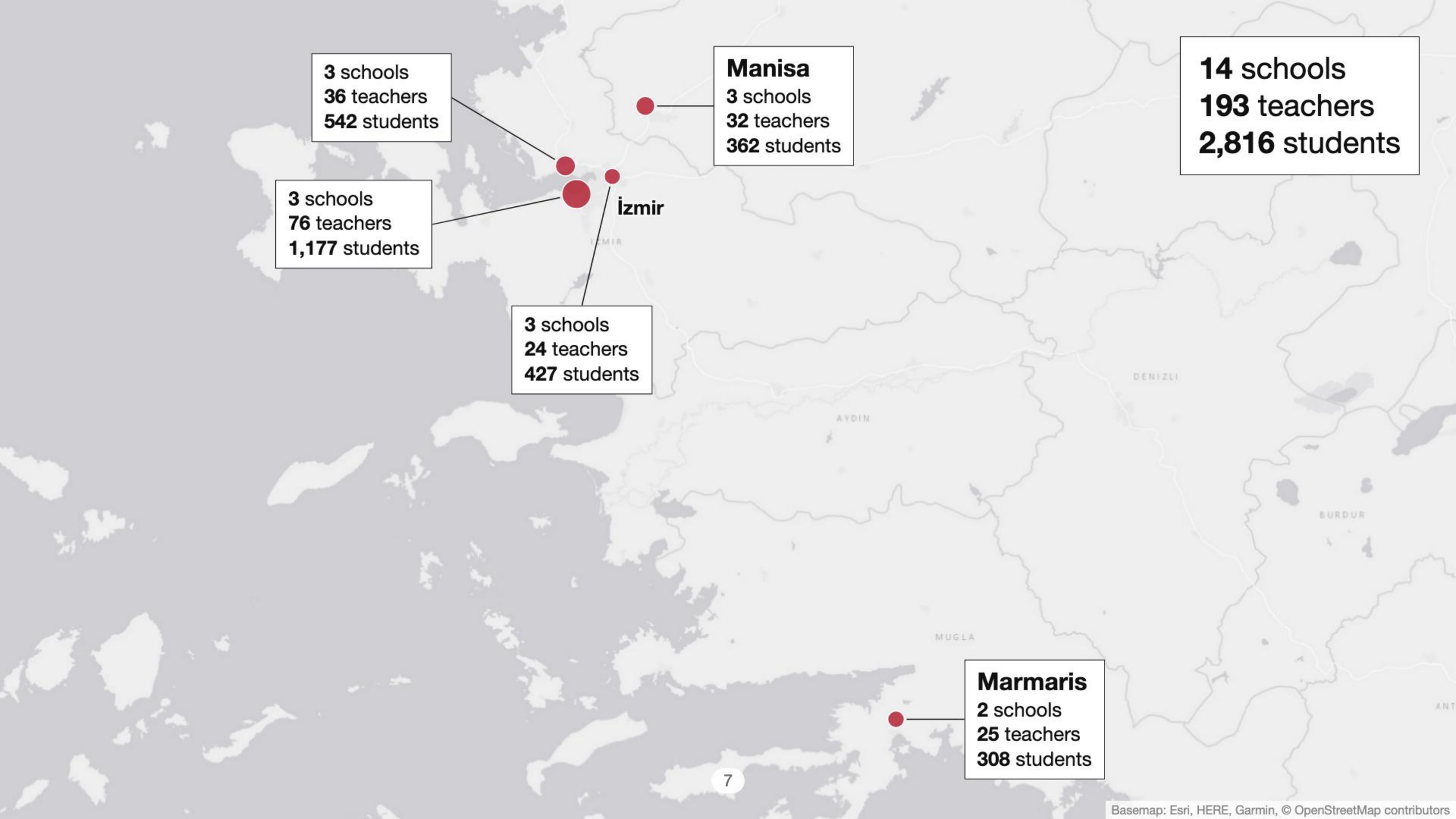
Doshi & Hauser 2024
Farber et al. 2014

Five questions about what happens when teachers use AI

1. **Adoption:** do teachers use the tool?
2. **Usage:** what do they use it for?
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A preregistered field experiment in 14 Turkish schools

14	schools, grades 5–12
85	school–department clusters
193	teachers
2,816	students
14,198	student–course observations


3 schools
36 teachers
542 students
Manisa
3 schools
32 teachers
362 students
14 schools
193 teachers
2,816 students
3 schools
76 teachers
1,177 students
İzmir
3 schools
24 teachers
427 students
Marmaris
2 schools
25 teachers
308 students
İZMIR
AYDIN
DENIZLI
MUGLA
BURDUR
Basemap: Esri, HERE, Garmin, © OpenStreetMap contributors



Control

Business-as-usual professional development



AI Access

A one-hour training and a custom GPT-4o tool built on the national curriculum



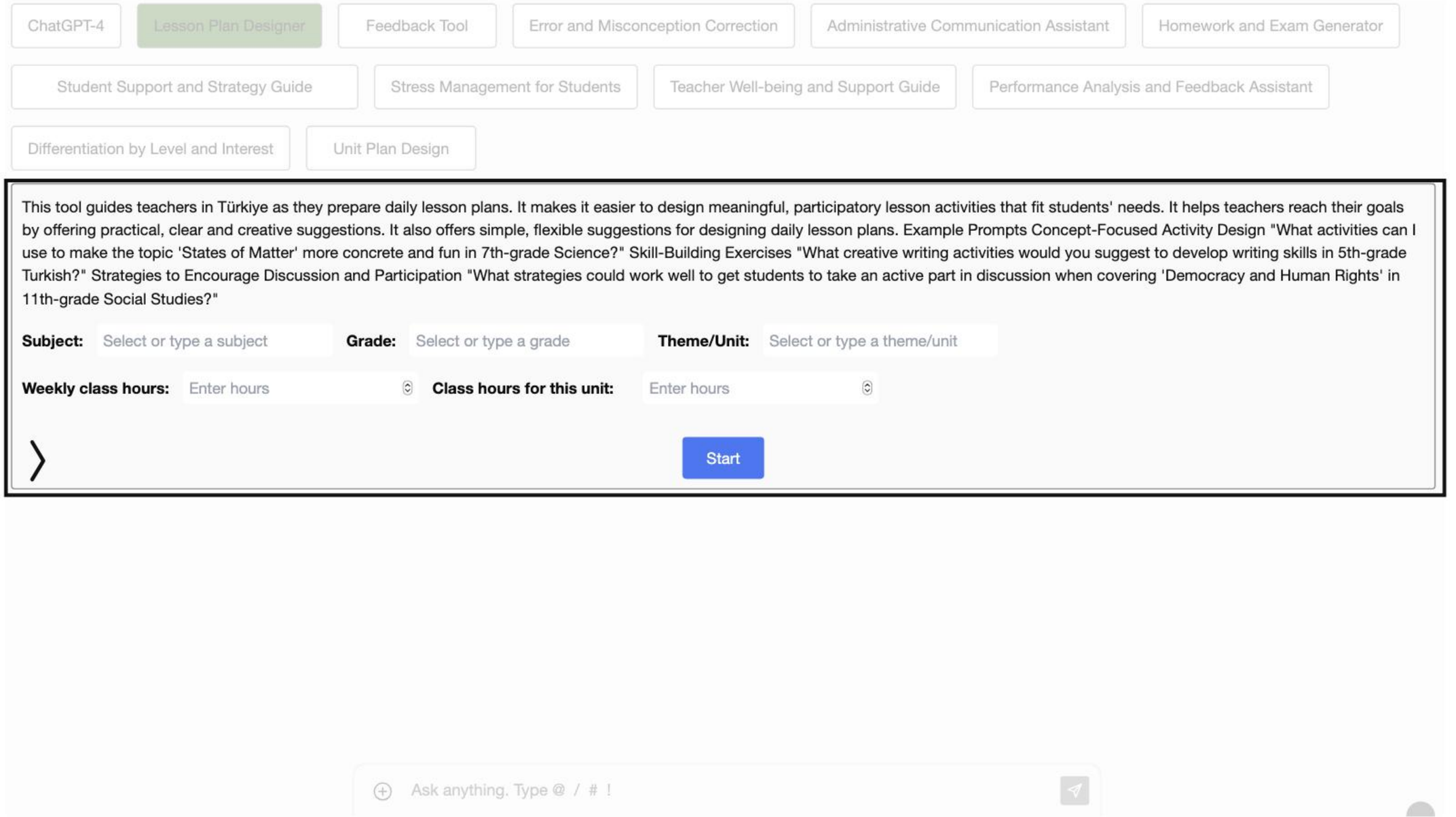
AI Access + Reminder

+ weekly emails showing each teacher's own usage, as a nudge

Both AI arms are **pooled** and compared with control.
Estimates are **intent-to-treat**.

Unit of randomization: the school–department

Details


ChatGPT-4
Lesson Plan Designer
Feedback Tool
Error and Misconception Correction
Administrative Communication Assistant
Homework and Exam Generator
Student Support and Strategy Guide
Stress Management for Students
Teacher Well-being and Support Guide
Performance Analysis and Feedback Assistant
Differentiation by Level and Interest
Unit Plan Design
This tool guides teachers in Türkiye as they prepare daily lesson plans. It makes it easier to design meaningful, participatory lesson activities that fit students' needs. It helps teachers reach their goals by offering practical, clear and creative suggestions. It also offers simple, flexible suggestions for designing daily lesson plans. Example Prompts Concept-Focused Activity Design "What activities can I use to make the topic 'States of Matter' more concrete and fun in 7th-grade Science?" Skill-Building Exercises "What creative writing activities would you suggest to develop writing skills in 5th-grade Turkish?" Strategies to Encourage Discussion and Participation "What strategies could work well to get students to take an active part in discussion when covering 'Democracy and Human Rights' in 11th-grade Social Studies?"
Subject:
Select or type a subject
Grade:
Select or type a grade
Theme/Unit:
Select or type a theme/unit
Weekly class hours:
Enter hours
Class hours for this unit:
Enter hours
Start
Ask anything. Type @ / # !

Your AI Usage Report This Week

AI Teaching Assistant team Sun, Feb 9, 2025

Hello Teacher,

Here is some data on your use of the AI tool:

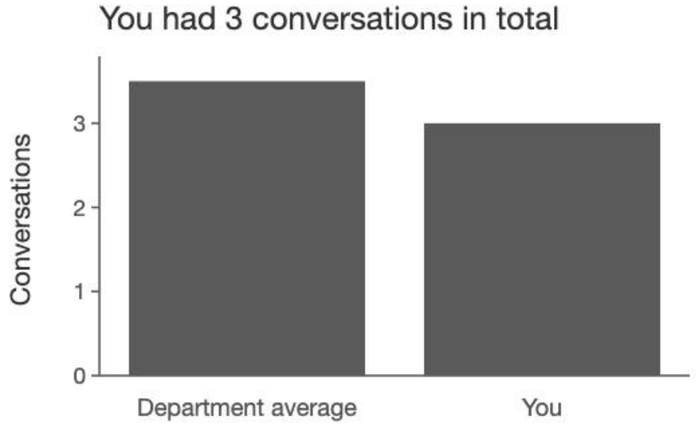
- You sent **8** messages.
- You had **3** conversations.
- You used the AI for about **1** minute in total.

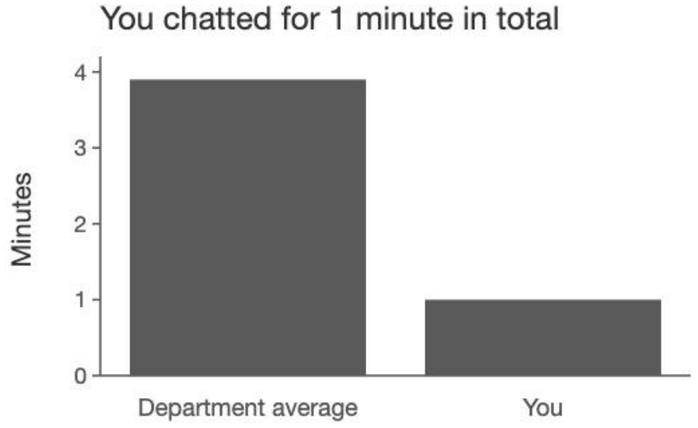
You've made a great start toward exploring more! Wishing you a successful new week.

Feel free to reach out with any questions.

Best wishes







Timeline

August–December 2024

Pre-period

Baseline standardized test scores collected

January 2025

Training

Teachers receive AI training and complete questionnaires

February–May 2025

Intervention Period

Treated teachers use AI tool
Control teachers teach as usual

Standardized test scores collected

May 2025

Endline

Teachers and students complete questionnaires

Fall Semester 2024

Winter Break

Spring Semester 2025

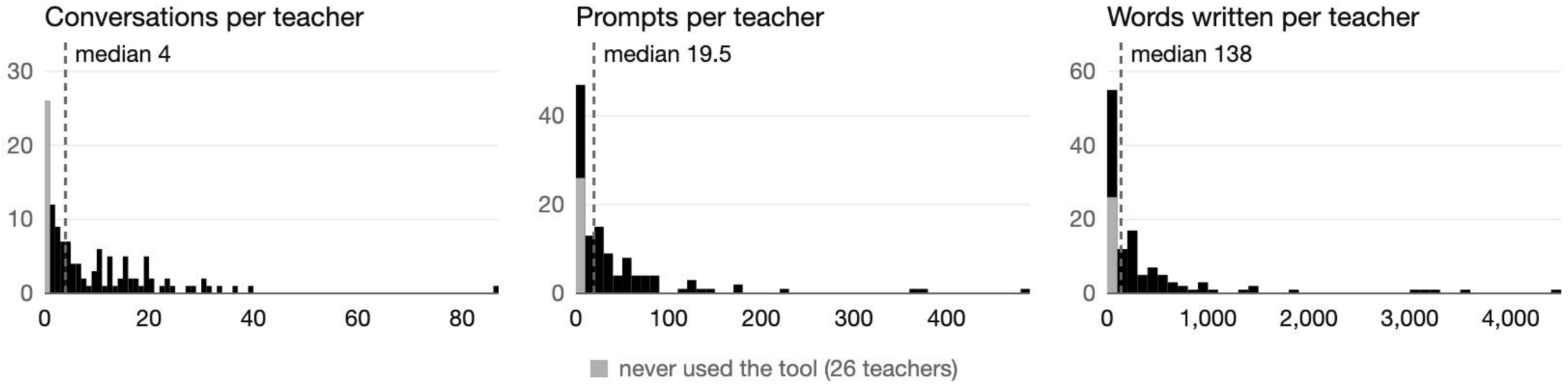
Five questions about what happens when teachers use AI

1. **Adoption:** do teachers use the tool?
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Most teachers did adopt the AI tool

78%

of treated teachers (94 of 120) had at least one conversation



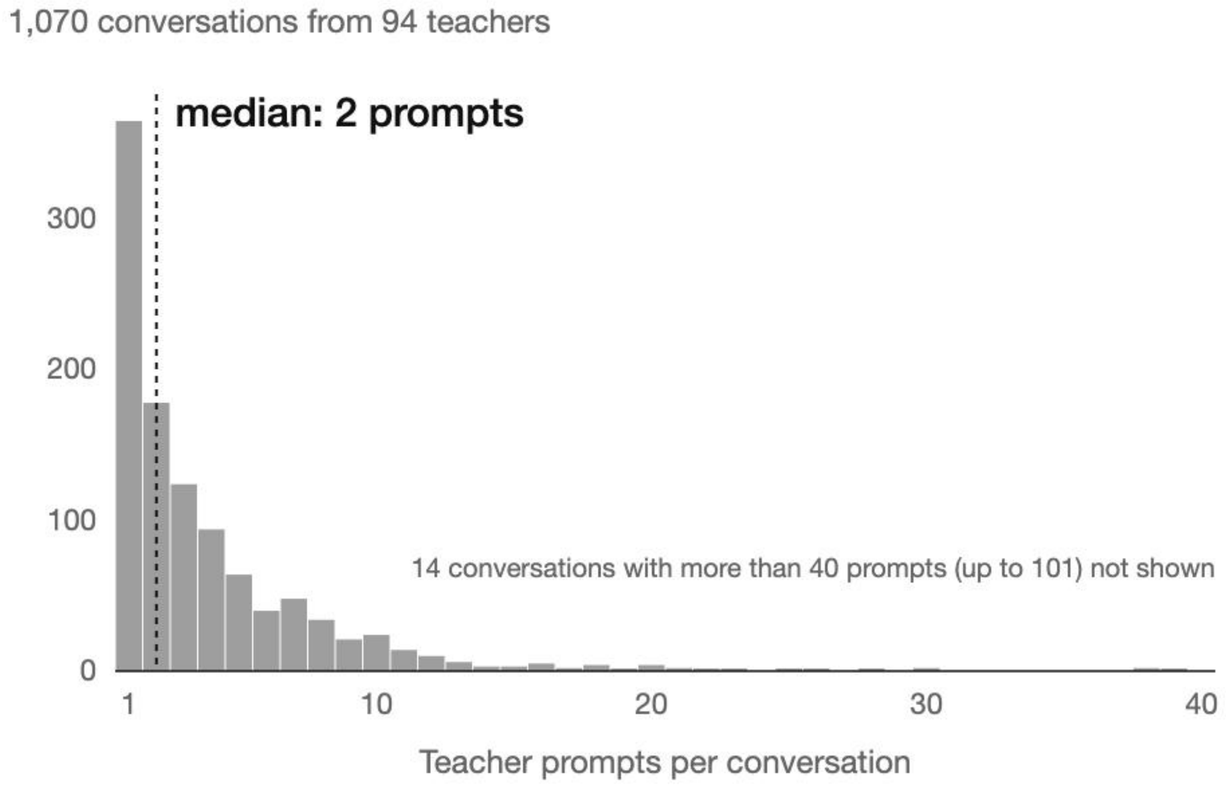
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Teachers delegated: they asked for finished materials and rarely iterated

2

teacher prompts in the median conversation: little back-and-forth



A chemistry teacher accepted the first lesson plan the tool offered

Teaching material preparation

Lesson planning: a chemistry teacher, high school. From the tool logs, translated

Make an inference about how scientific knowledge changes through atomic theories.
Course: [Chemistry] Grade: [9th Grade]

Here is a concise plan:
1. Objective: explain how atomic theories changed.
2. Activity: timeline discussion.
3. Assessment: short-answer quiz.
[…]

Thank you, that's suitable.

You're welcome.

A geography teacher asked the tool how to fix a misconception

Misconception correction: a geography teacher, high school. From the tool logs, translated

Grade: [11] Unit: [Turkish agriculture and livestock]
Weekly hours: [4] Hours for the unit: [4]

Great, you will teach 11th graders about agriculture and livestock in Turkey. […] Are there errors or misunderstandings that students often have on this topic? […]

They make mistakes on where agricultural products are distributed on the map.

I see, they struggle with the distribution of agricultural products on the map. […] How are you teaching this topic right now? If you like, I can suggest activities or explanations that address these misunderstandings directly.

Suggest, please.

Of course! Here are a few suggestions: 1. Visual aids and map work […] 2. Group work and discussion […] 3. Analysis of wrong examples […]

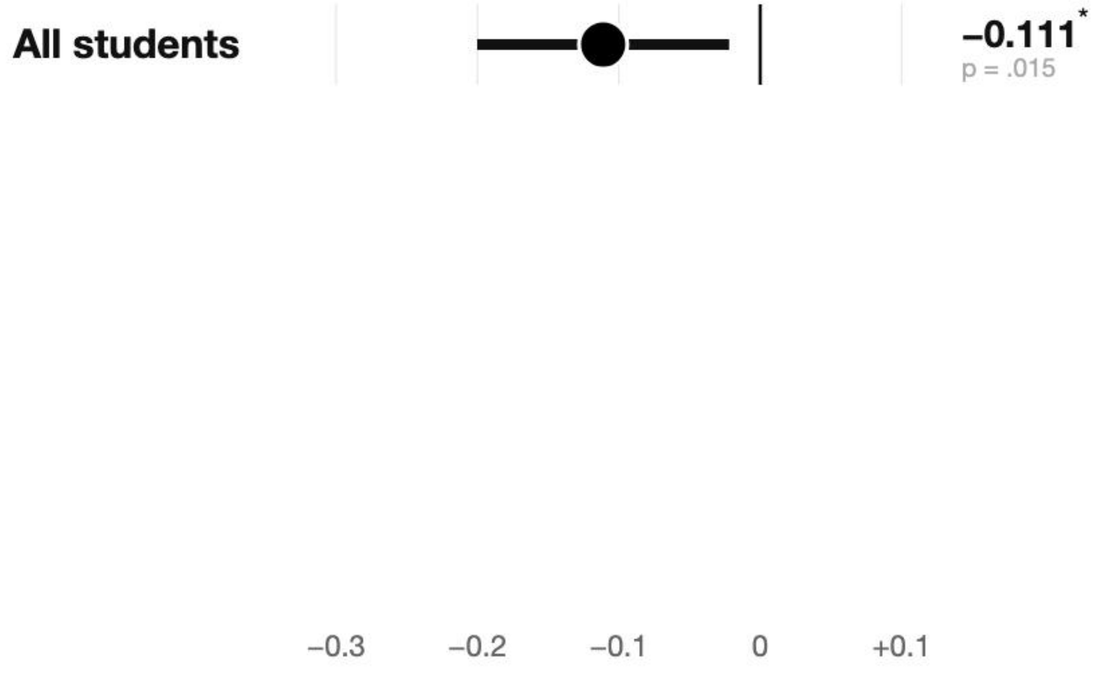
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AI lowered students' intrinsic motivation

Intrinsic motivation

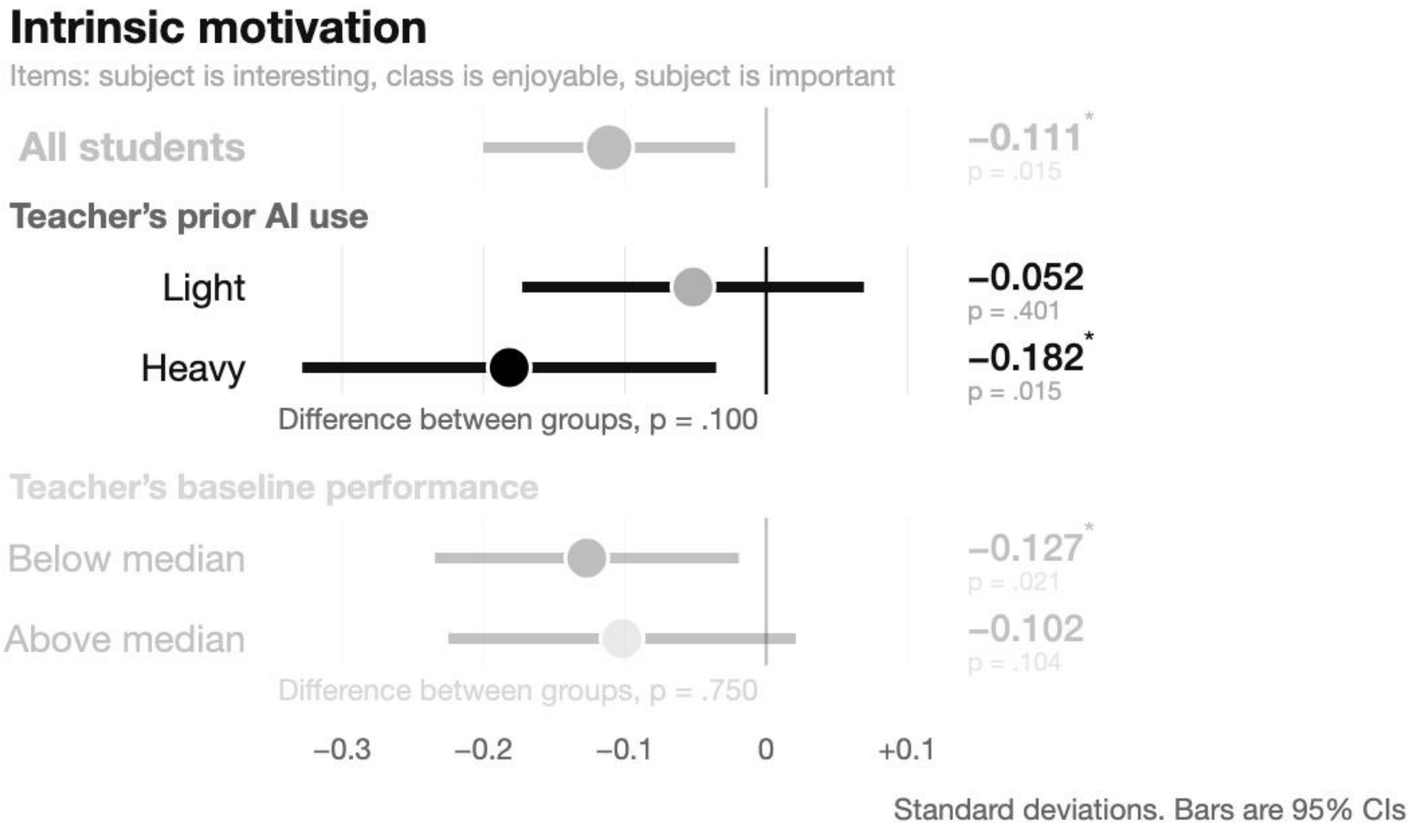
Items: subject is interesting, class is enjoyable, subject is important



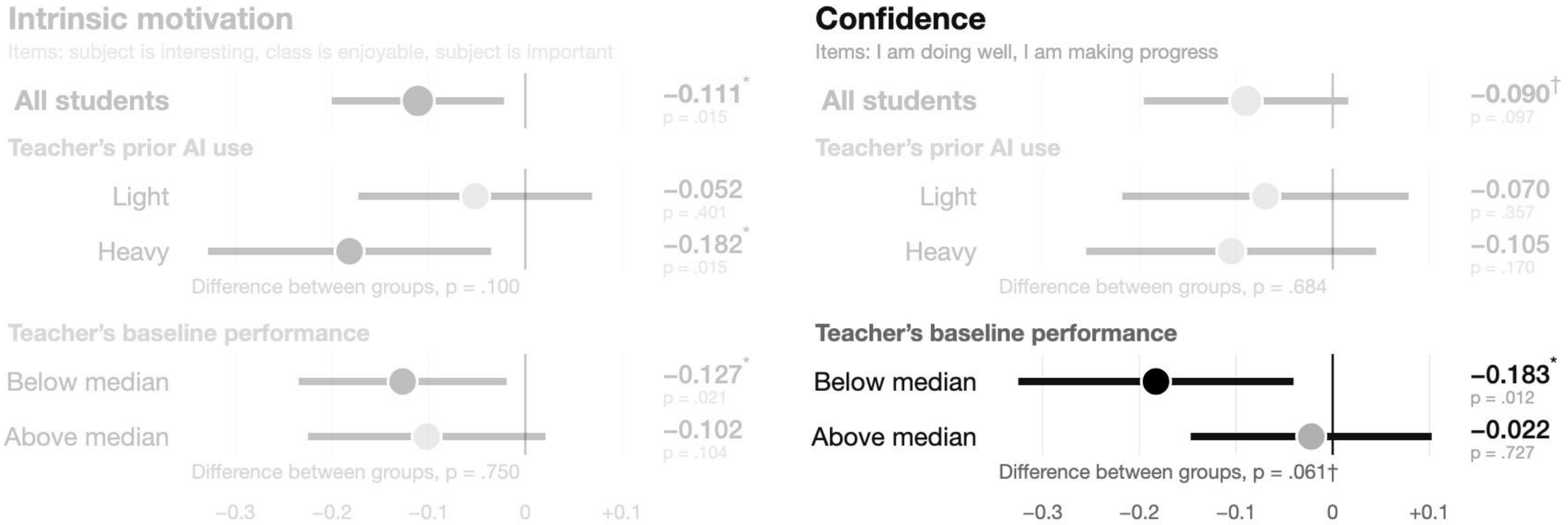
Details

Fredricks et al. 2004

…especially for teachers higher in baseline AI use



Confidence fell less



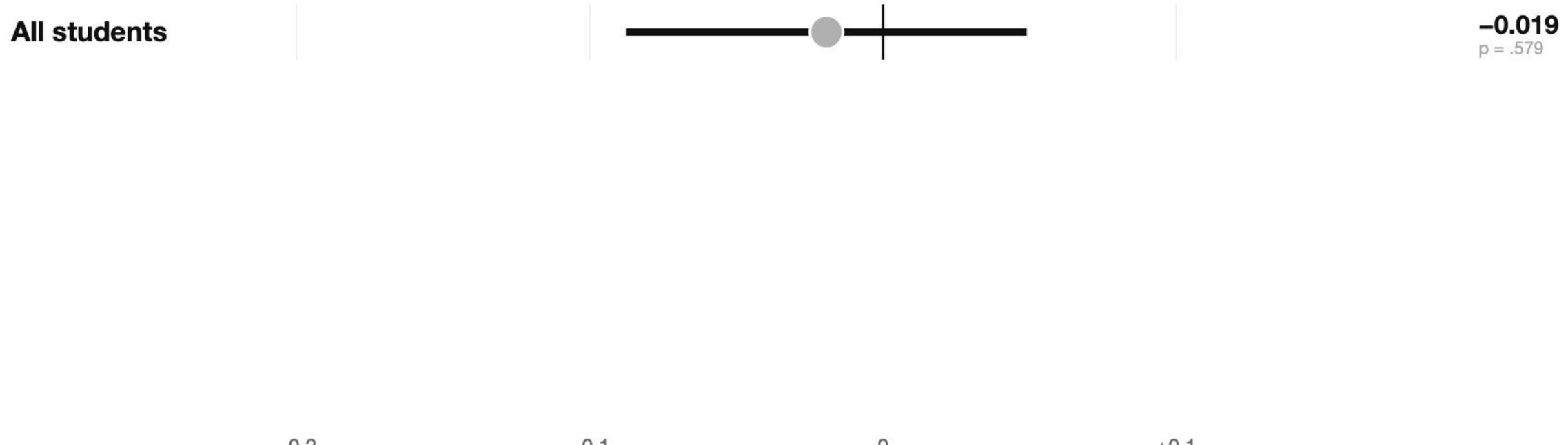
Standard deviations. Bars are 95% CIs

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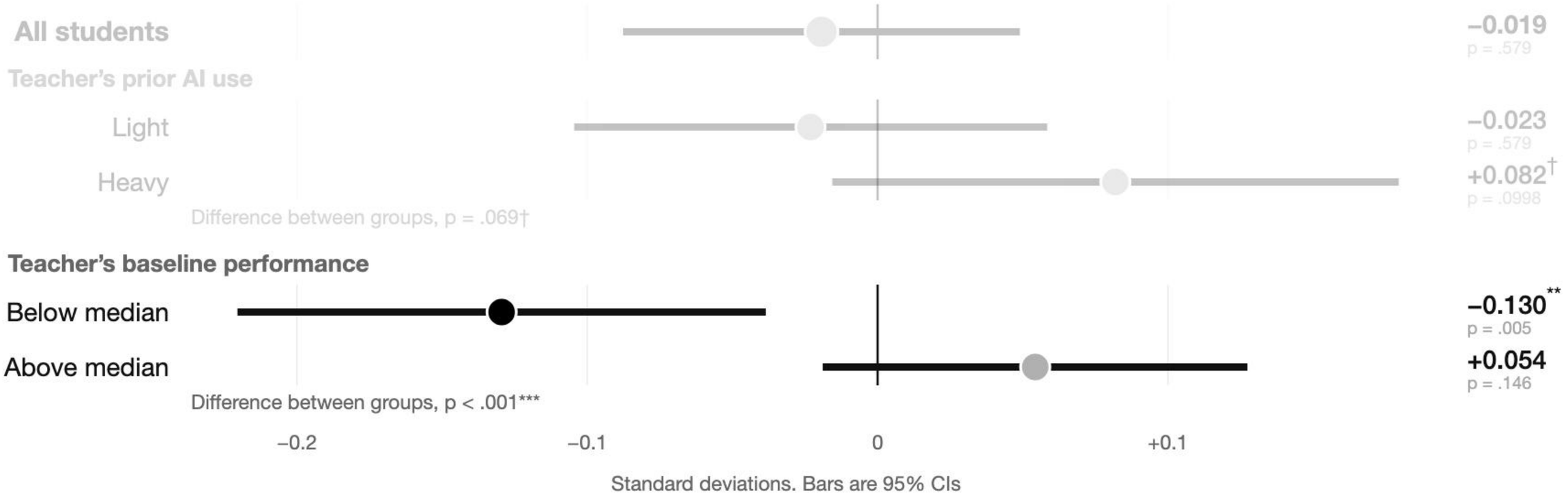
On average, AI did not move standardized test scores

Standardized test scores



…but it did harm students of lower-performing teachers

Standardized test scores



Why was AI harmful?

Effort signal

AI-made materials lack the teacher's own style, so students read them as fake or low-effort.

Doshi & Hauser 2024
Moon et al. 2026

Skill substitution

Teachers offload the pedagogical reasoning that makes materials work, and their skills erode.

Otis et al. 2026
Dell'Acqua 2022

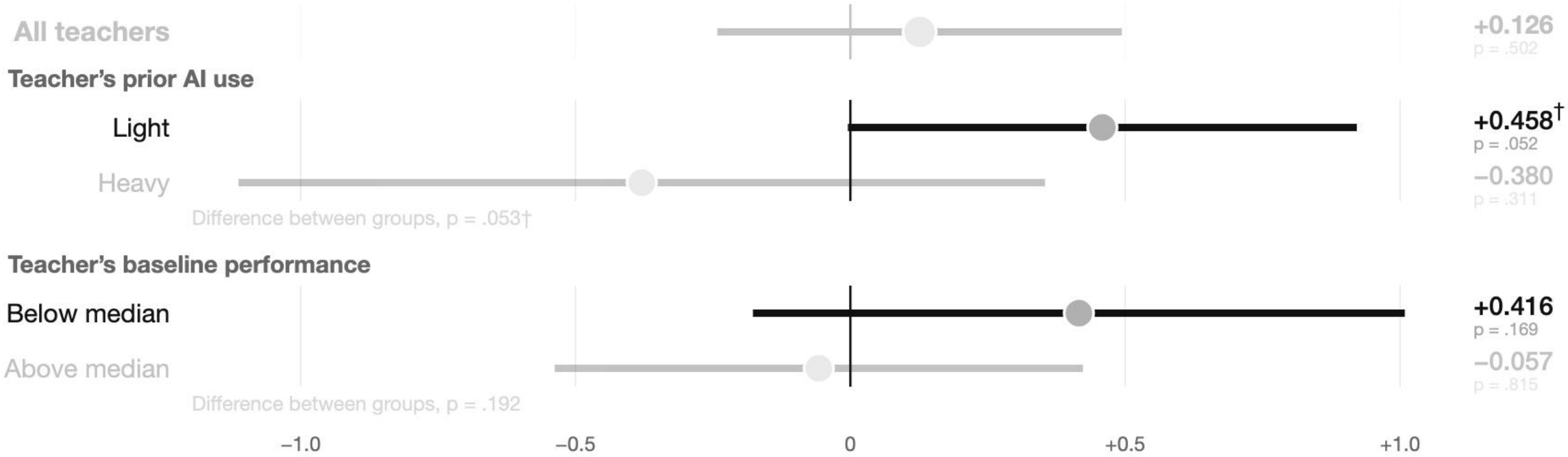
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Teachers did not update their views on AI

even as their students' intrinsic motivation fell

Teacher beliefs about AI



Standard deviations. Bars are 95% CIs

"What overall impact do you believe AI tools have on students' learning outcomes?"

Details

Limitations



Duration

We observe one semester.



Tool specificity

We test one AI tool design.



Contamination

Control teachers could use free AI tools.

We cannot assume AI helps in schools without more careful design

Optimists

We are too cautious and leave gains on the table.

Gans 2025

Pessimists

Rapid adoption outruns our understanding of the harms.

Bick et al. 2026

Schools should scale AI for teachers with care.

Take home

Most teachers adopted AI, mostly delegating rather than co-creating.

Their students found those classes less interesting, enjoyable, and important.

Confidence fell less, mostly among students of weaker teachers.

On average, standardized test scores did not change.

But students of lower-performing teachers had learning losses.

Teachers did not update their views on AI.

Thank you

Benjamin Lira, blira@upenn.edu

Paper

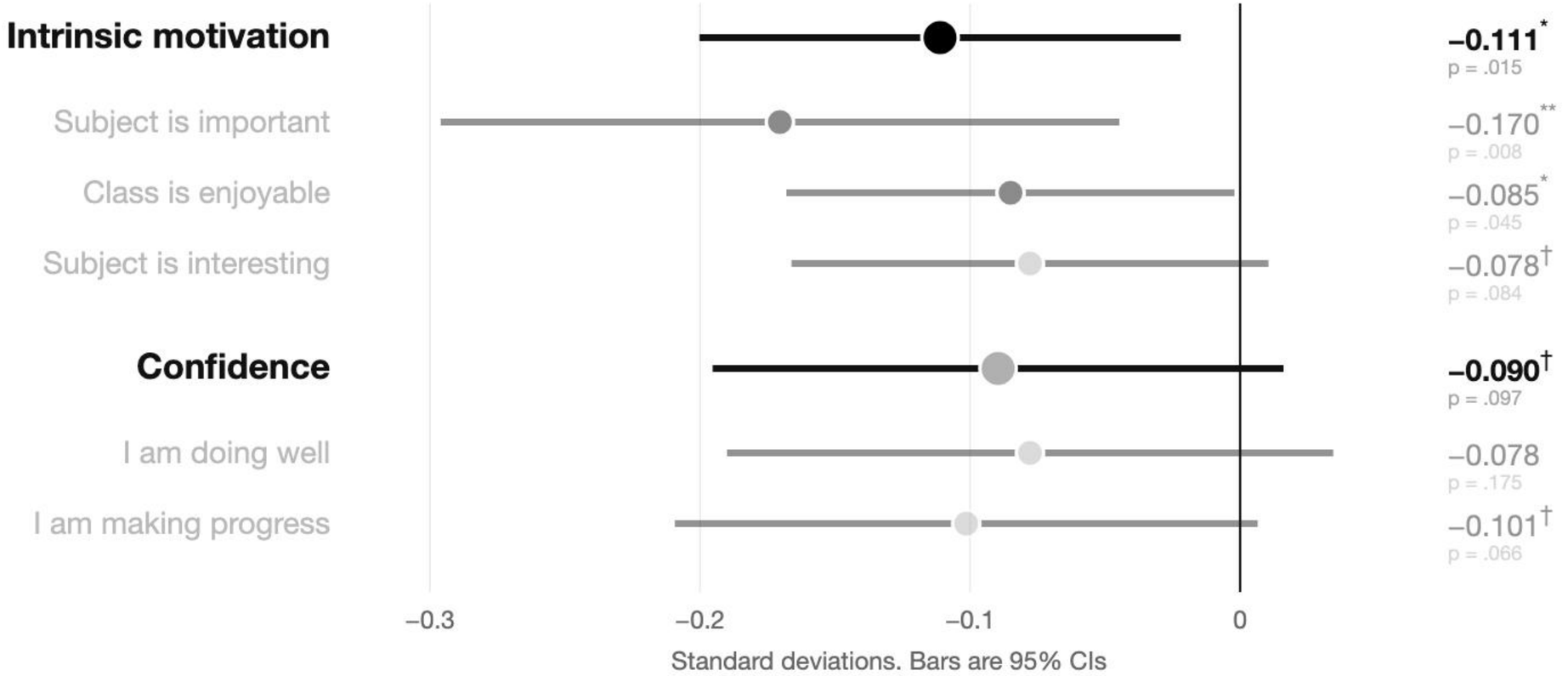
Code and data

Robustness checks

Attrition	Response rates did not differ by condition. Lee bounds stay negative.
Within-school variation	Every school had AI and control teachers.
Fixed effects	Still negative, though smaller, with department, school and student fixed effects.
Single items	No one survey item drives the result.
Arms and dosage	Same pattern for each AI arm and for AI-teacher share.

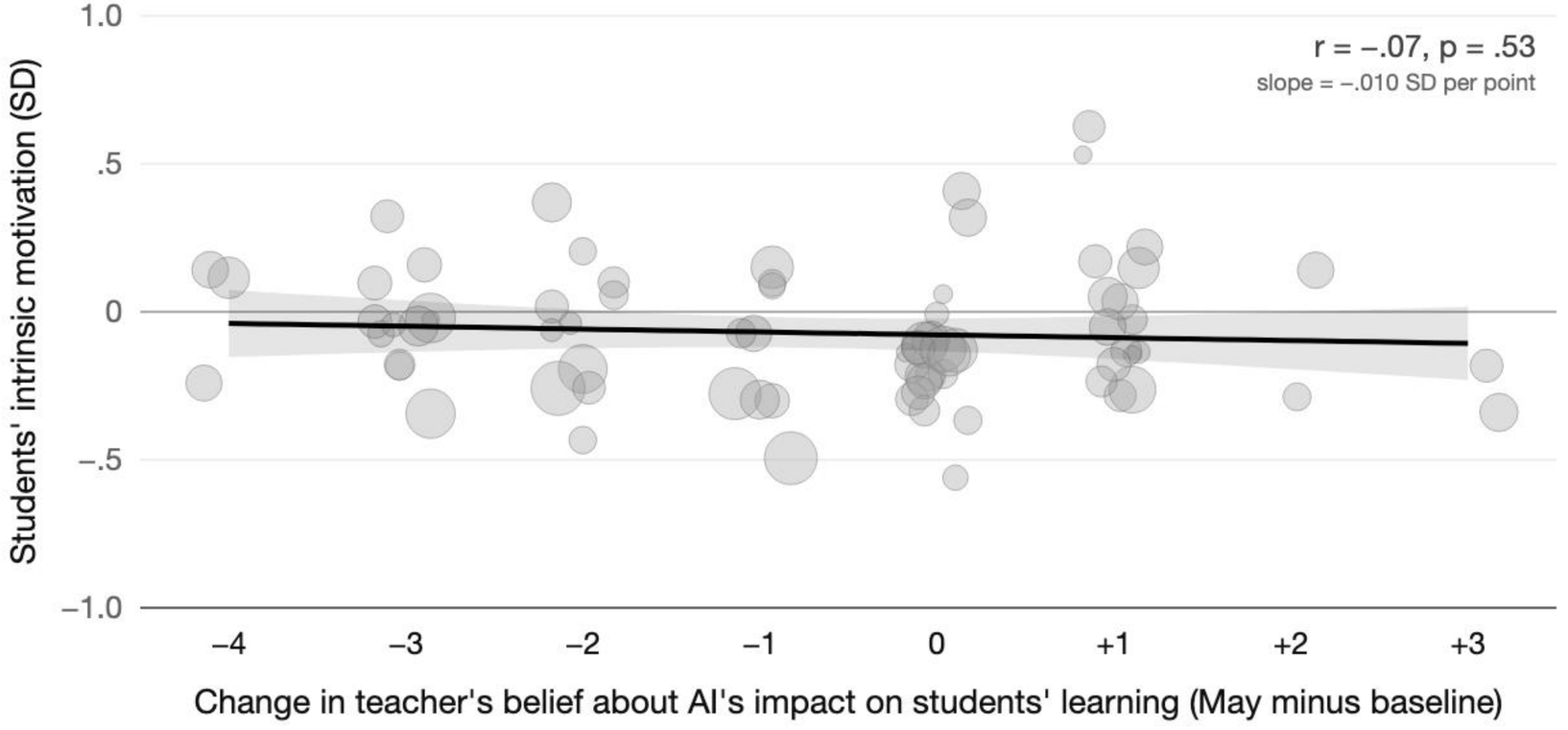
Lee (2009)

No single survey item drives the result



Back

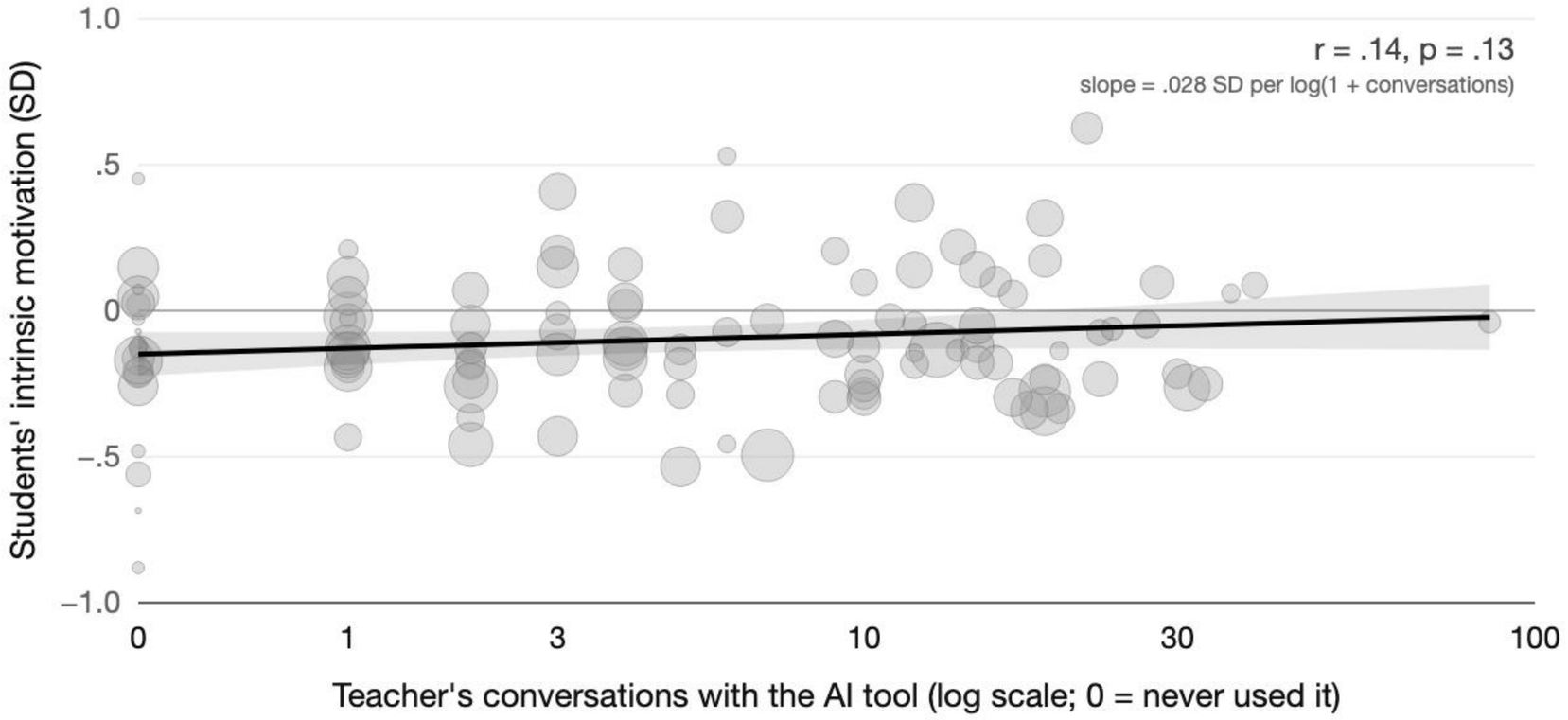
Teachers with less intrinsically motivated students did not grow more skeptical of AI



Descriptive; usage and beliefs were not randomized. N = 77 treated teachers. Dot area = number of surveyed students.

Back

Students' intrinsic motivation did not fall with heavier AI use



Descriptive; usage and beliefs were not randomized. N = 114 treated teachers. Dot area = number of surveyed students.

Estimation

$$Y_{ic} = \alpha + \boldsymbol{\beta} \cdot \mathrm{AI}_d + \gamma \cdot Y_{ic}^{\mathrm{pre}} + \varepsilon_{ic}$$

i student (or teacher), *c* course, *d* school–department (unit of randomization)

β: effect of giving teachers AI (intent-to-treat, both AI arms pooled)

γ: baseline control for test scores and teacher beliefs (students had no pre-survey)

Standard errors clustered by school–department

$$Y_{ic} = \alpha + \beta_1 \cdot \mathrm{AI}_d + \beta_2 \cdot M + \boldsymbol{\beta_3} \cdot (\mathrm{AI}_d \times M) + \gamma \cdot Y_{ic}^{\mathrm{pre}} + \varepsilon_{ic}$$

β_3: does the effect differ by the teacher's prior AI use or baseline performance?
M = 1 if the teacher is above the median

Back

The two AI arms look alike: adoption and usage

Outcome	AI Access	AI Access + Reminder	Arms differ (p)
Adoption Treated teachers only; no control comparison			
Used the tool at least once	80% 24/30	78% 70/90	1.00 means: .78
Conversations per teacher	median 8, mean 9.3	median 4, mean 8.8	.55 means: .83
Prompts per teacher	median 24.5, mean 31.1	median 17, mean 45.1	.96 means: .36
Words written per teacher	median 113.5, mean 241	median 144, mean 435.7	.80 means: .11
Usage Conversations of treated teachers			
Share teaching material preparation	67% 185/278	66% 522/792	.93
Share instructional support	18% 51/278	16% 125/792	.50
Prompts per conversation	median 2, mean 3.4	median 3, mean 5.1	.57 means: **.02**

Treated teachers in the analytic sample: AI Access 30, AI Access + Reminder 90 (non-users count as zero); 278 and 792 conversations.
Used the tool: Fisher's exact test. Per-teacher counts: Mann–Whitney. Prompts per conversation: Mann–Whitney on teacher medians.
Means: OLS, SEs clustered by school–department (per teacher) or by teacher (per conversation). Shares: linear probability model clustered by teacher.

Model Back

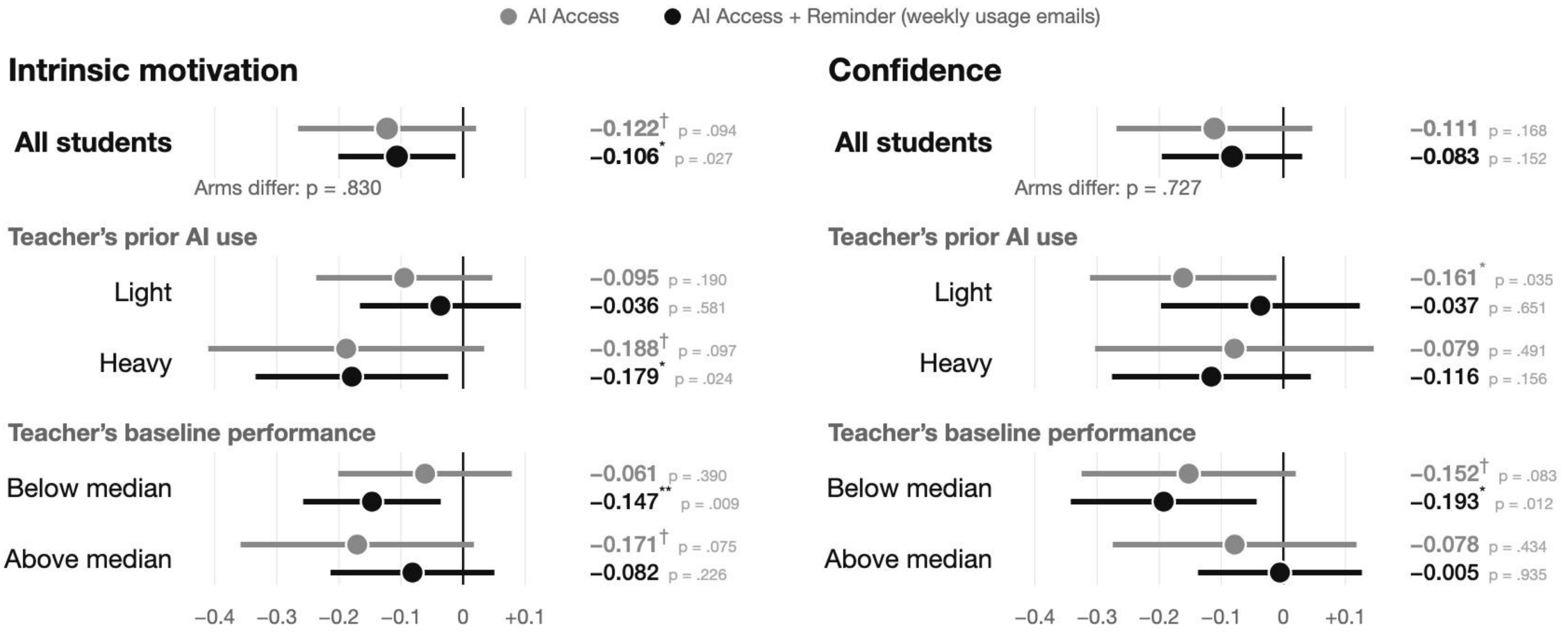
The two AI arms look alike: outcomes

Outcome	AI Access	AI Access + Reminder	Reminder – Access
Intrinsic motivation and confidence			
Intrinsic motivation	–0.12† p = .09 [–0.27, 0.02]	–0.11* p = .03 [–0.20, –0.01]	+0.02 [–0.13, 0.16] p = .83
Confidence	–0.11 p = .17 [–0.27, 0.05]	–0.08 p = .15 [–0.20, 0.03]	+0.03 [–0.13, 0.19] p = .73
Standardized test scores	–0.01 p = .81 [–0.09, 0.07]	–0.02 p = .54 [–0.10, 0.05]	–0.01 [–0.09, 0.06] p = .73
Teacher beliefs	+0.22 p = .38 [–0.27, 0.71]	+0.09 p = .66 [–0.30, 0.48]	–0.13 [–0.58, 0.32] p = .57

N, student–course survey responses: AI Access 1,808, AI Access + Reminder 5,754, control 3,730.
N, student–course test scores: AI Access 2,543, AI Access + Reminder 6,991, control 4,548. N, belief-survey teachers: AI Access 23, AI Access + Reminder 54, control 41.
Effects in SD vs control, 95% CI in brackets: OLS on both arm indicators, baseline control for test scores and beliefs.
Arm difference: Wald test of equal effects. SEs clustered by school–department.

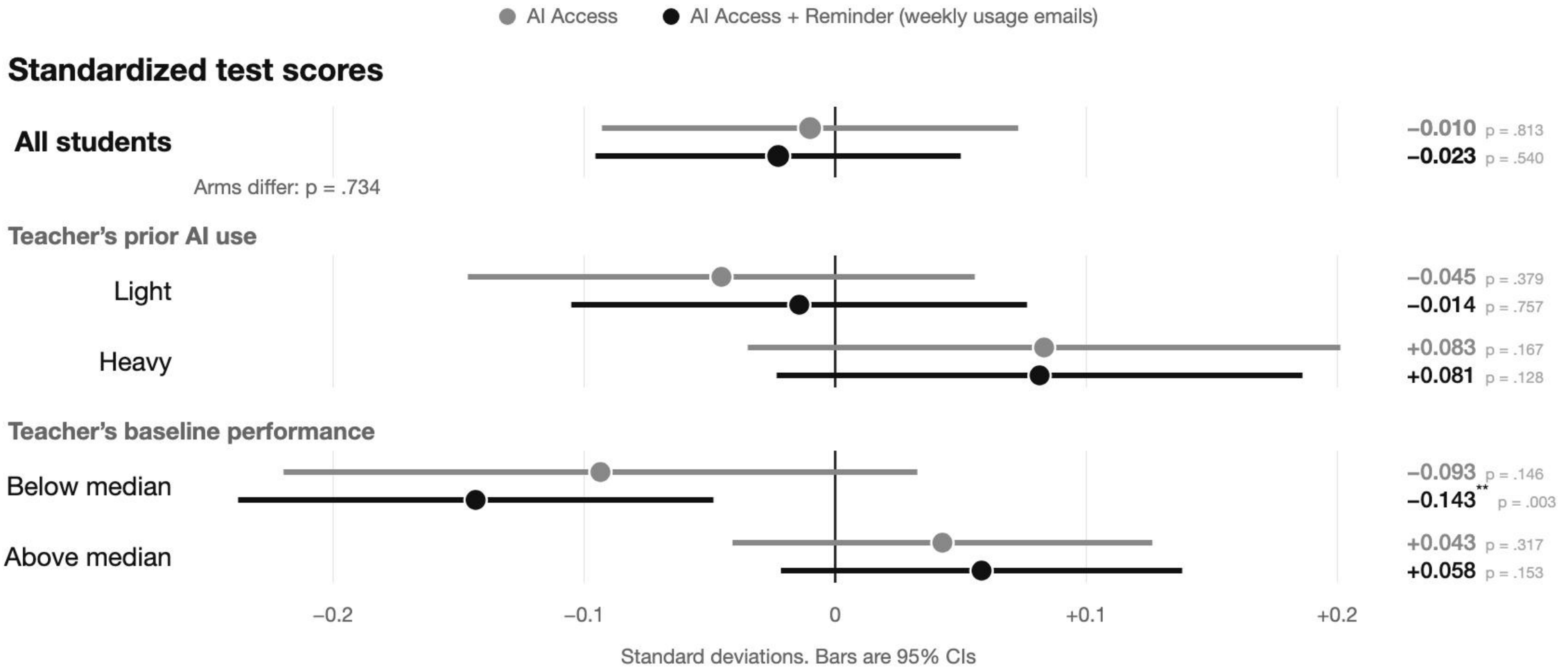
Model Back

By treatment arm: intrinsic motivation and confidence



Standard deviations. Bars are 95% CIs

By treatment arm: standardized test scores



By treatment arm: teacher beliefs about AI

